

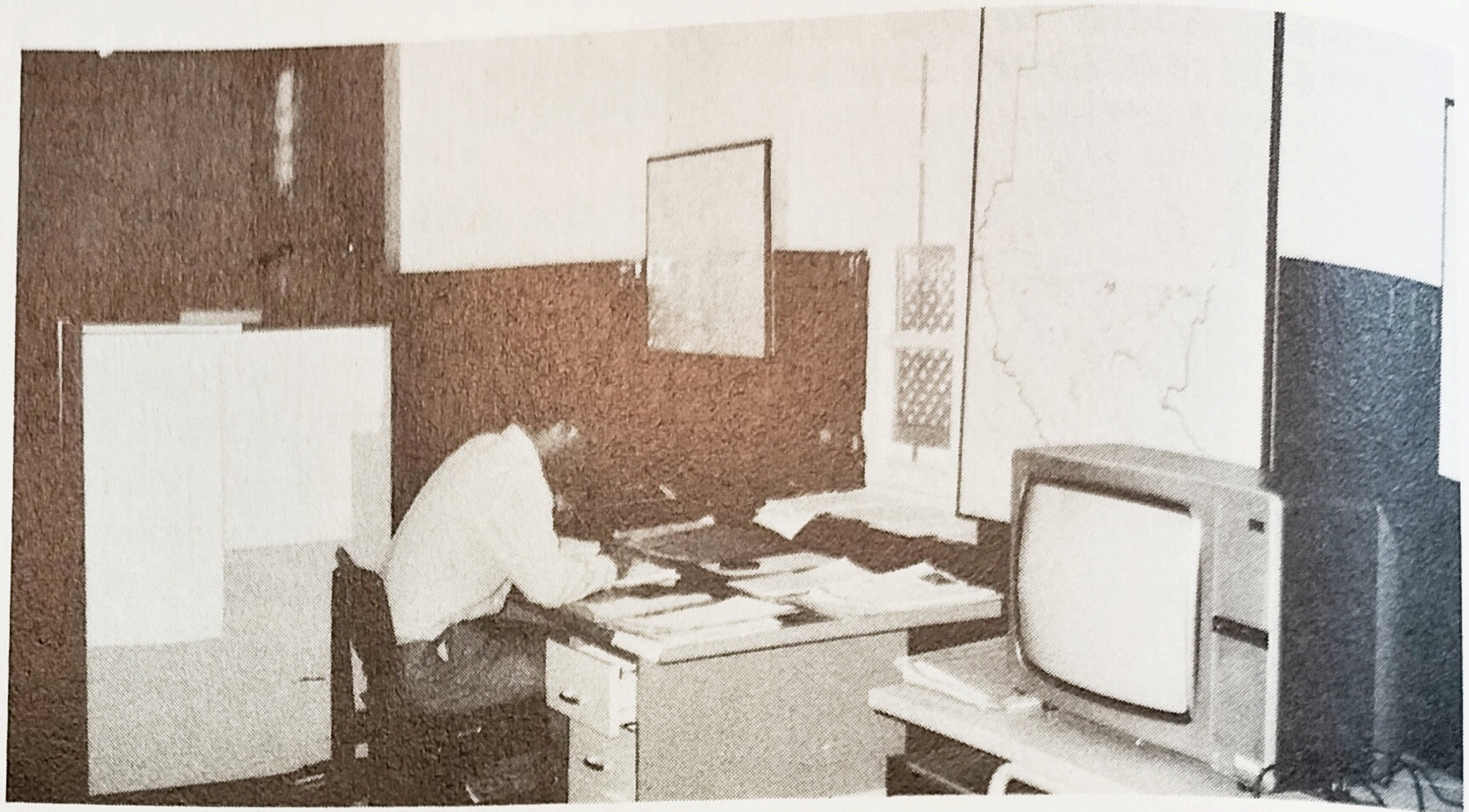
The "RICSU" Concept

Computers that ease human misery

Disasters are characteristically sources of misinformation. Communication problems, inadequate assessments, differences in personal or organizational perceptions of the same facts, physical or bureaucratic constraints in sharing information, errors in analysis, or simple misunderstandings — these are some of the reasons why information on disasters, can be so inadequate from one relief operation to the next, and lead to poor decisions in relieving affected populations.

Information in relief is rarely thought of as an entity in itself, whereas in fact good information is as critical to disaster management as fuel is to a logistics operation. This is especially true in disasters as complex and widespread as the effects of drought in the Sudan, Africa's largest country, where well over six million persons have been considered in danger of death. The magnitude and multiplicity of national and international relief aid and programmes can easily lead to duplication, inappropriateness or waste in the absence of sound information.

Experience shows that purveyors of disaster relief — donor governments, international organizations, the governments of affected countries — will react massively with visible material assistance and programmes. On the other hand, information mechanisms, to insure



RICSU staff conferring on logistical problems.

that the relief corresponds to the requirements, will come late if at all — when the level of misinformation becomes so apparent that systematizing information is an act of desperation rather than foresight.

There is a different approach in Sudan, where since February 1985, information on drought relief operations has been the responsibility of a specialized Unit jointly established and operated by Sudanese and United Nations staff with the financial support of the Government of the United Kingdom.

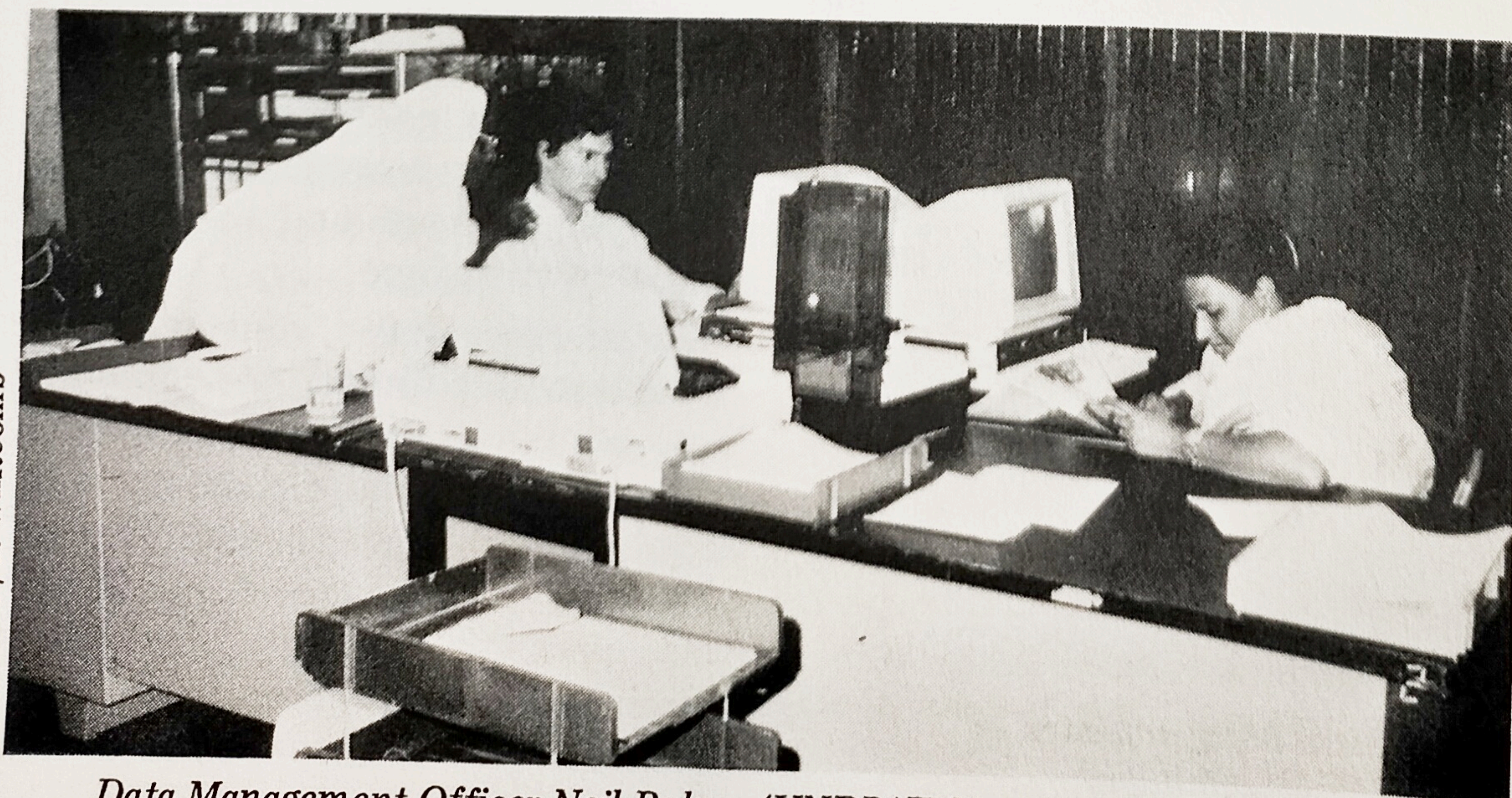
The Relief Information and Coordination Support Unit — "RICSU", as it is familiarly called in Khartoum — was specifically conceived to provide information to

national and international drought relief officials, with decision-making responsibilities, be they in Sudan, at the inter-organizational focal points in Geneva (UNDRO) and New York (OEQA), or within the headquarters of interested international organizations and Ministries of donor governments.

In January 1985, officials of the National High Commission for Drought and Desertification, the UN Resident Co-ordinator and the newly-assigned UNDRO delegate agreed to collaborate on strengthening the capacity of the national drought relief mechanism to monitor the effects of the drought and insure the necessary national and international relief measures. The first step in doing this was to develop the capacity to know and make known, continuously, what the drought's effects were and what could be done to eliminate or reduce them.

The subsequent establishment and operation of the Unit were based on three principles, reflecting a particular approach to national and international drought relief management which UNDRO has encouraged since first directly associated with drought relief*:

- Accurate, complete and up-to-date information is critical to the



Data Management Officer Neil Bohne (UNDP/JPO) using personal computer.

conduct of effective drought relief.

- Information must be developed, processed and disseminated rationally and systematically.

- A focal point for information on national and international drought relief is best operated as a joint national and international effort.

The Unit got off the ground quickly. Administratively, it was placed within the Secretariat to the National High Commission. Physically it was located in the Department of Social Welfare, responsible for this Secretariat. The Department made offices available which were rapidly equipped to meet the needs of an operational information unit. In particular, an Information Status Room was set up (*see picture*) which, with wall maps, charts, operational information files, and computer capability, could be freely accessible to all interested persons.

The Unit's capacity to "manage" information was heightened considerably by the introduction of two micro-computers. (A promising technical development in disaster management, the micro-computer is being used increasingly by UN and NGO relief entities both in Sudan and other countries facing emergencies). The computers, portable, compatible with the UN "main-frame" in Geneva which services UNDRO, and equipped with a communications modem making the transmission of data possible over international telephone lines, were brought to Khartoum in early February by an UNDRO consultant. The consultant trained national and international staff in the use of the computers and worked with them to adapt the software to the RICSU's needs: (1) Data management — recording and manipulating information on international relief contributions, (2) Word processing — rapid up-dating and dissemination of operational information, (3) Communications — transmission of computerized data to the Geneva "main-frame".

But more significant than the administrative and technical characteristics of the Unit, was the human dimension. A national civil servant with background in socio-economics

was seconded from the Presidency to head the Unit, and the responsibilities of the UNDRO delegate were expanded to include acting as his counterpart. Further staff, for a total of thirteen, including support staff, was provided by the Department of Social Welfare, by UNDP and by UNICEF, similarly on a national/international counterpart basis. (The UN staff included two UNDP Junior Professional Officers, a Canadian and an Italian, from posts in Sri Lanka and Nigeria who were transferred to Sudan on short notice).

The RICSU officially opened its doors on 26 February 1985, following the issuance of a Ministerial decree defining its role and place within the national relief mechanism. Shortly thereafter, a RICSU Consultative Working Group was established to bring together, at the

could meet as many inter-organizational needs as possible, and to cross-check information on international contributions in different sectors. From the work of this group, different formats for recording and reporting contributions were agreed to and procedures established to ensure maximum accuracy and currency.

The regular compilation and communication (including computer-to-computer communications to Geneva and, via Geneva, to points in other capitals) of information on contributions was one of several products of the RICSU. Another was the issuance of information bulletins on the situation in different drought-affected regions of the country. Staff of the Unit, in addition to conducting an active debriefing programme, have themselves participated in assessment



RICSU Research and Studies Officer Luca Pignatelli at work.

working level, representatives of national and international (U.N., inter-governmental, bi-lateral, NGO) relief organizations. The Working Group, meeting on alternate weeks to the UN Resident Coordinator's meeting of international aid representatives, focused on specific issues hampering or facilitating relief, which could be resolved within the Group, or through referral to higher authority.

A second Working Group, bringing together "users" of computer in U.N. and international relief organizations, was formed to ensure maximum compatibility between computers and programmes, to see that the programmes developed

missions through the Sudan, to cross-check and evaluate needs and the effectiveness of relief efforts.

In May, the National High Commission was further organized to strengthen disaster management capability, the need for which was in large measure stimulated by the information which RICSU was able to bring systematically to the attention of the national and international decision makers.

*Chad, 1982, where the Ministère de la lutte contre les calamités naturelles and UNDRO, with the help of the Swiss Government Disaster Relief Unit (SDRU), had established a relief co-ordination and information center around which a joint national/international Comité d'action was decreed, and still operates today.